

Electricity from Photosynthesis

Researchers at the Centre de Recherche Paul Pascal (CNRS), France have transformed chemical energy generated by photosynthesis into electrical energy by developing a novel biofuel cell

Feature

to install it for the last 2 years. I stay at Vashi and my bungalow is facing the creek where wind pressure is good," he said. This system has helped him reduce his conventional grid consumption by around 25% and he uses the system for around four hours daily.

According to Tongay, as most of the office building in most of the cities are working in the day time, they can easily install a couple of panels on their office premises to take care of their secondary lighting needs. "It will all ultimately add up and will make us more sustainable," says Tongay.

Rain water harvesting

July 26th, 2005 is a date that is etched in the memory of many Mumbaikars. The western suburbs in Mumbai were flooded for days with electricity cut off and many parts of the city not getting drinking water. Sealine society was one rare exception which had no problems of water shortage.

When Chandra moved into the housing society in 2001, Sealine society was facing heavy water shortages. Due to the residence of a minister in the society, there were a large number of security personnel who also used the society's resources, thus putting a strain on it. Around two water tankers supplied water to the society every week. "Not only did this

push our society's water bills through the roof, but we found that the water provided by the tankers needed to be filtered to be consumed," reminisced Chandra.

In 2004, Chandra proposed the rain water harvesting plan to society members. The rain water from the terrace and compound is collected in a 10,000 litre tank that is under the ground. A 70 feet channel with bare bottom (i.e. a channel having a base of mud, sand and pebbles) guides the water to the ground. This rain water seeps through the ground and charges

the ground water table. "The speed of charging is low as compared to collection of water when it rains heavily. If it's not charged at that rate then it will flow into the drains. So we have three 6-inch wide, 100 feet deep bore wells to increase the rate of charging the ground water table," explained Chandra. This harvested water can be pumped out at the rate of 6000 litres / hour to all the homes with the help of a submersible pump. As water for non drinking purposes is supplied thanks to rain water harvesting, the society only needs drinking water from the municipality, cutting consumption by around 50 per cent.

This initiative provides the society with enough water for all the non drinking purposes. But being the innovative person that he is, Chandra took rain water harvesting one step further by installing a water treatment and filtering plant. "We have no shortage of drinking water. Our society has sufficient water for the next 10 years," he claims.

Other Initiatives

The individuals we spoke to believe in spreading their knowledge. They are optimists and believe that time is not far when switching to alternative sources of energy is going to be inevitable.

Chandra is consulted by at least 2-3

societies every two weeks regarding adoption of solar energy in their premises. Apart from this consulting, Chandra is the Chairman of an organisation called Jaago Mumbai.

In this report we have covered a limited number of people due to space constraints. But there are countless others out there who are doing their bit. With time we are sure, things will improve on the alternative sources of energy front. They have

to. We are left with no other choice but to adopt green measures. 

JAAGO MUMBAI

Jaago Mumbai is an organisation formed by the citizens of Mumbai with an objective to empower the community with the knowledge and awareness of making their surroundings more environment friendly. It plans to make a municipality garden into an eco-friendly one, which will act as a working model for rain water harvesting, using solar energy for lighting and vermi composting. It plans to come out with a community radio station which will have programs which will educate the community about energy conservation, disaster management among other things.

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